Chayanov's "Journey of My Brother Alexei”

The narrative establishes Alexei Kremnev, a Soviet official in 1921 Moscow, who through a mystical experience (after reading Herzen) is transported to 1984 in an alternate future where peasant culture has triumphed over urban socialism.

CHAPTER ONE
in which the benevolent reader becomes acquainted with the triumph of socialism and the hero of our novel, Alexei Kremnev

It was well past midnight when the holder of labor book No. 37413, formerly known in the bourgeois world as Alexei Vasilyevich Kremnev, left the stuffy, overcrowded large auditorium of the Polytechnical Museum. A foggy haze of autumn night shrouded the sleeping streets. Rare electric lanterns seemed lost in the receding distances of intersecting alleys. The wind tossed yellow leaves on the boulevard trees, and the fairy-tale bulk of the Kitay-gorod walls gleamed white in the darkness.

Kremnev turned onto Nikolskaya Street. In the foggy haze, it seemed to have assumed its former contours. In vain wrapping himself in his coat against the piercing night dampness, Kremnev looked sadly at the Vladimir Church, the chapel of Panteleimon. He remembered how, with heart pounding, he as a first-year law student many years ago had bought here, to the right, from the bookseller Nikolaev "The Alphabet of Social Sciences" by Flerovsky; how three years later he had begun his icon collection, finding at Elisey Silin's the Novgorod Savior; and those many long hours when, with the burning eyes of a proselyte, he had rummaged through the manuscript and book treasures of Shibanov's antique shop—there where now, in the dim lantern light, one could read the brief inscription "Glavbum."

Driving away criminal memories, Alexei turned toward the Iverskoy Gates, passed the first House of Soviets, and was swallowed by the gloom of Moscow's alleys.

And in his head, words, phrases, fragments of phrases painfully burned, just heard at the Polytechnical Museum meeting:

"By destroying the family hearth, we thereby strike the final blow against the bourgeois order!"

"Our decree prohibiting home cooking casts out from our existence the joyful poison of the bourgeois family and strengthens the socialist principle for ages to come."

"Family comfort breeds proprietary desires, the joy of the householder hides within it the seeds of capitalism."

His tired head ached and already habitually thought without thinking, realized without drawing conclusions, while his legs mechanically moved toward the half-ruined family hearth, condemned within a week to complete destruction according to the recently published and explained decree of October 27, 1921.

CHAPTER TWO
telling of the influence of Herzen on the inflamed imagination of a Soviet official

Spreading butter on a large piece of bread—that blessed gift of God-protected Sukharevka—Alexei poured himself a glass of already boiling coffee and sat in his work chair.

Through the glass of the large window, the city was visible; below, in the foggy haze of night, milky-white patches stretched in rows of street lanterns. Here and there in the black masses of buildings, windows still glowed dimly yellow.

"So it has come to pass," thought Alexei, gazing into the night Moscow. "Old Morris, virtuous Thomas, Bellamy, Blatchford and you, others, kind and dear utopians. Your lonely dreams have become universal conviction, your greatest daring—official program and everyday routine! In the fourth year of the revolution, socialism can consider itself the unchallenged master of the globe. Are you satisfied, pioneer-utopians?"

And Kremnev looked at the portrait of Fourier hanging above one of the bookcases in his library.

However, for himself, an old socialist, a major Soviet worker, head of one of the departments of the World Economic Council, somehow not everything was right in this embodiment; he felt some vague pity for what had passed, some web of bourgeois psychology still obscured his socialist consciousness.

He walked across the carpet of his study, glanced over the bindings of books, and unexpectedly for himself noticed a row of volumes on a half-forgotten shelf. The names of Chernyshevsky, Herzen, and Plekhanov looked at him from leather spines of solid bindings. He smiled, as one smiles at childhood memories, and took from the shelf the volume of Herzen in the Pavlenkov edition.

The clock struck two. They chimed with a prolonged hiss and fell silent again.

Good, noble, and childishly naive words opened before Kremnev's eyes; reading captivated, excited, as memories of first youthful love excite, first youthful oath.

His mind seemed freed from the hypnosis of Soviet everyday life; new, non-banal thoughts stirred in his consciousness; it became possible to think in other variants.

Kremnev excitedly read a long-forgotten prophetic page:

"Weak, sickly, stupid generations," wrote Herzen, "will somehow drag on until the explosion, until that or another lava which will cover them with a stone shroud and consign them to the oblivion of chronicles. And then? And then spring will come, young life will boil up on their coffin lid, the barbarism of infancy, full of unfinished but healthy forces, will replace the barbarism of old age, wild fresh power will unfold in the young breast of young nations, and a new circle of events and a third volume of universal history will begin.

Its fundamental tone can be understood now. It will belong to social ideas. Socialism will develop in all its phases to extreme consequences, to absurdities. Then again a cry of denial will burst from the titanic breast of the revolutionary minority, and again will begin the mortal struggle in which socialism will take the place of present conservatism and will be defeated by the coming, unknown revolution."

—A new uprising. Where is it? And in the name of what ideals?—he thought.—Alas, liberal doctrine has always been weak in that it could not create an ideology and had no utopias.

He smiled with regret. Oh, you Milyukovs and Novgorodtsevs, Kuskovs and Makarovs, what utopia will you sketch on your banners?! What, besides the obscurantism of capitalist reaction, do you have to replace the socialist order?! I agree... we live far from in a socialist paradise, but what will you give in exchange?

The book of Herzen suddenly slammed shut with a crack by itself, and a pack of folios in octavo and folio fell from the shelf.

Kremnev started.

The room smelled suffocatingly of sulfur. The hands of the large wall clock spun faster and faster and disappeared from sight in furious rotation. Sheets from the tear-off calendar noisily tore off by themselves and whirled upward, filling the room with paper whirlwinds. The walls somehow distorted and trembled.

Kremnev's head spun, and cold sweat moistened his forehead. He started, rushed in panic horror to the door leading to the dining room, and the door slammed shut behind him with the crack of breaking wood. In vain he searched for the electric light button. It was not in its usual place. Moving in darkness, he bumped into unfamiliar objects. His head spun and consciousness clouded, as during seasickness.

Exhausted by efforts, Alexei sank onto some sofa, never before here, and consciousness left him.

CHAPTER THREE
depicting Kremnev's appearance in the land of utopia and his pleasant conversations with a utopian Muscovite about the history of twentieth-century painting

A silvery bell woke Kremnev.

"Yes, yes, it's me," a female voice was heard. "Yes, arrived... obviously, last night... Still sleeping... Very tired, fell asleep without undressing... Good. I'll call."

Kremnev raised himself on the sofa and rubbed his eyes in amazement.

He lay in a large yellow room, flooded with morning sun rays. Furniture of a strange and unknown style to Alexei, made of red wood with green-yellow upholstery, yellow half-open window curtains, a table with bizarre metal instruments surrounded him. In the adjacent room, light female steps were heard. The door creaked and all fell silent.

Kremnev jumped to his feet, wishing to account for what had happened, and quickly approached the window.

In the blue sky, like ships, floated thick autumn clouds. Beside them, somewhat lower and quite close to the earth, glided several airplanes, now small, now large, of bizarre shape, gleaming in the sun with rotating metal parts.

Below stretched a city... Undoubtedly, this was Moscow.

To the left rose the bulk of the Kremlin towers, to the right Sukharevka glowed red, and there, in the distance, the Kadashevs proudly rose.

A view familiar for many, many years.

But how everything had changed around. The stone masses that once obscured the horizon had disappeared; whole architectural groups were absent; the Nirensee house was not in its place... Instead, everything around was drowning in gardens... Spreading tree canopies flooded all the space almost to the Kremlin itself, leaving solitary islands of architectural groups. Street-alleys crossed the green, already yellowing sea. Along them, living streams flowed with pedestrians, automobiles, carriages. Everything breathed with some distinct freshness, confident vigor.

Undoubtedly, this was Moscow, but a new, transformed and enlightened Moscow.

"Can it be that I have become the hero of a utopian novel?" exclaimed Kremnev. "I confess, quite a stupid situation!"

To orient himself, he began to look around, hoping to find some starting point for understanding the new world surrounding him.

"What awaits me beyond these walls? The blessed kingdom of socialism, enlightened and consolidated? The wondrous anarchy of Prince Peter Alekseevich? Returned capitalism? Or perhaps some new, previously unknown social system?"

As far as could be judged from the window, one thing was clear: people lived at a sufficiently high level of prosperity and culture and lived together. But this was still too little to understand the essence of the surrounding.

Alexei greedily began to examine the objects surrounding him, but they gave very little.

For the most part, these were ordinary things, distinguished only by the thoroughness of their finish, some emphasized precision and luxury of execution, and the strange style of their forms, partly reminiscent of Russian antiquity, partly the ornaments of Nineveh. In a word, it was a strongly Russified Babylon.

Above the sofa where Kremnev had awakened hung a large painting that attracted his attention.

At first glance, one could confidently say that this was a classical work of Pieter Bruegel the Elder. The same composition with a high horizon, the same bright and precious colors, the same short figures, but... on the panel were painted people in colored frock coats, ladies with umbrellas, automobiles, and undoubtedly the subject served something like the departure of airplanes. The same character was borne by several reproductions lying on the neighboring table.

Kremnev approached the large work table, made of something like dense cork, and hopefully began to examine the books scattered on the table. These were the 5th volume of "The Practice of Socialism" by V. Sher, "The Renaissance of the Crinoline, an Essay in the Study of Contemporary Fashion," two volumes of Ryazanov's "From Communism to Idealism," the 38th edition of the memoirs of E. Kuskova, a magnificent edition of "The Bronze Horseman," a brochure "On the Transformation of V-energy," and finally, his hand, trembling with excitement, took up a number of a fresh newspaper.

Excited, Kremnev unfolded the small sheet. On the masthead stood the date: 23 hours evening, September 5, 1984. He had jumped over 60 years.

There could be no doubt that Kremnev had awakened in the country of the future, and he plunged into reading the newspaper sheet.

"The Peasantry," "The Past Epoch of Urban Culture," "To the Sad Memory of State Collectivism"... "This was in capitalist times, that is, almost in prehistoric times"... "The Anglo-French, isolated system"—all these phrases and dozens of other phrases pierced Kremnev's brain, filling his soul with amazement and great desire to know.

A telephone call interrupted his reflections. Steps were heard in the next room. The door swung open, and with a stream of sun rays entered a young girl.

"Ah, you're already up..." she said cheerfully. "I overslept your arrival yesterday."

The bell rang again.

"Excuse me, this must be my brother worrying about you... Yes... Yes, he's already up... I don't know, really... I'll ask now... Do you speak Russian, Mr.... Charlie... Men... if I'm not mistaken?"

"Of course, of course," unexpectedly for himself and very loudly exclaimed Alexei.

"Speaks, and even with a Moscow accent... good, I'll hand over the receiver."

The confused Kremnev received in his hands something resembling a telephone receiver of olden times, heard a greeting spoken in a soft bass, a promise to pick him up at three o'clock, assurances that his sister would take care of everything, and, hanging up the apparatus, realized quite, quite clearly that he was being taken for someone else, named Charlie Men.

The girl was no longer in the room. With desperate determination, Alexei rushed to the table, hoping to find in the papers and piles of telegrams at least some enlightenment of the surrounding mystery.

Luck favored him. The first letter he took was signed Charlie Men, and in a few phrases expressed the latter's desire to visit Russia and familiarize himself with its engineering installations in the field of agriculture.

CHAPTER FOUR
continuing the third and separated from it only so that chapters would not be very long

The door opened, and the young hostess entered the room, carrying above her head a tray with steaming cups of morning breakfast.

Alexei was charmed by this utopian woman, her almost classical head, ideally set on a strong, long neck, broad shoulders and full breast, lifting with each breath the collar of her blouse.

The minute silence of first acquaintance was soon replaced by lively conversation. Kremnev, avoiding the role of narrator, led the conversation into the area of art, assuming that this would not trouble the girl, living in rooms where wonderful pieces of painting hung on the walls.

The young girl, whose name was Paraskeva, spoke with the ardor of youthful enthusiasm about her favorite masters: old Bruegel, Van Gogh, old Rybnikov and the magnificent

Ladonov. A flaming devotee of neorealism, she sought in art the secrets of things, something either divine or devilish, but exceeding human powers.

Recognizing the supreme value of all existence, she demanded from the artist congeniality with the creator of the universe, valued in painting the power of enchantment, the Promethean spark giving new essence, and in essence was close to the realism of the old Flemish masters.

From her words, Kremnev understood that after the painting of the epoch of the great revolution, marked by futurism and extreme decomposition of old traditions, came the period of baroque-futurism, of tamed and sweet futurism.

Then, as a reaction, as a sunny day after a storm, thirst for craftsmanship came to the fore; the Bolognese began to come into fashion, the primitivists were somehow immediately forgotten, and the halls of museums with paintings by Memling, Fra Beato, Botticelli and Cranach almost found no visitors. However, submitting to the circle of times and not lowering their height, craftsmanship gradually received a decorative inclination and created the monumental canvases and frescoes of the epoch of the Varvarin conspiracy; a turbulent band passed the epoch of still life and blue gamut; then the ruler of world thoughts became the Suzdal frescoes of the XII century, and the realm of realism came with Peter Bruegel as the idol.

Two hours passed unnoticed, and Alexei did not know whether to listen to the deep contralto of his interlocutor or to examine the heavy braids plaited on her head.

Her wide open attentive eyes and the mole on her neck told him better than any proofs of the superiority of neorealism.

CHAPTER FIVE
in which Kremnev becomes acquainted with the utopian Moscow River market and the gardening character of Moscow

The doorbell rang with a silvery chime. Heavy steps sounded in the corridor, and a young man of about thirty entered the room. Tall, broad-shouldered, with a round, ruddy face and a small reddish beard, he looked at Kremnev with cheerful, laughing gray eyes.

"So our guest is already up," he said in a resonant bass, shaking Alexei's hand with a strong grip. "I am Nikifor, Paraskeva's brother. Welcome to our home, Mr. Men. I hope my sister has not bored you with her chatter about art?"

"On the contrary," replied Kremnev, "I found the conversation extremely interesting. Your sister is a remarkable young woman."

"Yes, she's a good girl," Nikifor agreed good-naturedly. "Well, shall we go? I promised to show you our Moscow. You'll see how much has changed since your time."

They went out into the street. The autumn sun shone warmly, and the air was filled with the scent of fallen leaves and something else—something fresh and garden-like that Kremnev could not immediately identify.

"First, let's go to the Moscow River market," said Nikifor. "You'll see there how we live now."

They walked along wide, tree-lined avenues. Kremnev could not recognize the city. Where once had stood rows of stone buildings, now stretched gardens, orchards, and vegetable plots. Houses—low, comfortable, buried in greenery—stood far apart from each other, connected by paved paths rather than streets.

"Where are all the people?" asked Kremnev, surprised by the emptiness of the former city center.

"Working in their gardens, of course," laughed Nikifor. "Everyone has their plot, their trees, their flowers. This is the foundation of our life. The city has become a garden, and the garden has become the city."

They approached the Moscow River. The market was in full swing. But what a market! No shouting, no dirt, no stench. Under light wooden canopies, neatly dressed peasants—men and women—sat behind counters laden with fruits, vegetables, flowers, and handicrafts. Everything was clean, orderly, beautiful.

Kremnev stopped before a counter where an old man was arranging bouquets of asters and chrysanthemums.

"How much?" asked Alexei automatically, reaching for his pocket.

The old man looked at him in surprise.

"Money? We don't use money here. Take what you like, if you have something to exchange."

Nikifor laughed and explained:

"We've long since done away with money, Mr. Men. Everything is exchanged directly, or simply given as gifts. The market is a place of meeting and exchange, not commerce. Each brings what he has grown or made, and takes what he needs. If you have nothing today, take anyway—you'll bring something tomorrow."

Kremnev walked through the market in a daze. He saw baskets of enormous apples, pears, grapes; vegetables of perfect form and enormous size; flowers of incredible beauty and variety. And the people—healthy, ruddy, cheerful, dressed in simple but good-quality clothing of some archaic cut—talked, laughed, argued about prices that did not exist.

"And this is Moscow?" he thought. "This is the city where three years ago people were eating corpses?"

They left the market and walked along the riverbank. The Kremlin rose white-walled across the river, but around it everything had changed. The enormous buildings of the Hotel Metropole, the State Duma, the City Council—all were gone. Instead, gentle hills covered with orchards sloped down to the water.

"Where are the factories?" asked Kremnev.

"Gone," replied Nikifor shortly. "We destroyed them. Not the buildings themselves, but the factory system. Each workshop now stands alone, surrounded by its own land. The workers live there, grow their food, make their products. No more concentration, no more proletariat, no more exploitation."

"But how do you produce complex things? Machines, for example?"

"Small workshops, cooperation, craftsmanship. We've returned to the guild system, but on a higher level. Each master has his apprentices, his plot of land, his independence. The state provides only coordination and large infrastructure—roads, canals, power stations."

They climbed a hill. Below, the Moscow River wound through a landscape of gardens and scattered buildings. The sun was setting, and the golden light played on the domes of distant churches.

"This is our utopia," said Nikifor quietly. "Not the industrial paradise of the socialists, not the mechanical perfection of the technocrats. A garden, Mr. Men. A garden where each person is a free cultivator, where work and life are one, where the earth feeds all and all feed the earth."

Kremnev was silent. He was thinking of the smoky factories, the crowded barracks, the hungry workers of 1921. And he felt something strange—something like envy, like regret, like the pain of a lost possibility.

CHAPTER SIX
telling of the trip to Sparrow Hills and the meeting with Nikonor

The next morning, Nikifor invited Kremnev to visit Sparrow Hills, where an old friend of his family lived—a certain Nikonor, a philosopher and historian who, according to Nikifor, could explain much about the new world.

They drove out of the city in a light automobile—electric, silent, smelling of ozone and autumn leaves. The roads were excellent, paved with some resilient material that absorbed sound. On both sides stretched endless gardens, orchards, fields. Occasionally they passed villages—clusters of low, comfortable houses, each with its own garden, its own outbuildings, its own character.

"How far does this extend?" asked Kremnev.

"To the Pacific," laughed Nikifor. "All of Russia is now one great garden. The cities have dissolved, the factories have scattered, the people have returned to the land. Not as primitive peasants, mind you—as free cultivators, educated, cultured, independent."

They arrived at Sparrow Hills. The house of Nikonor stood on a high bank overlooking the river valley—a low, sprawling building of wood and stone, covered with vines. An old man met them on the porch—tall, straight, with a long white beard and piercing blue eyes.

"Welcome, traveler from the past," he said, looking at Kremnev with an expression of kind curiosity. "I have been expecting you. Nikifor wrote that he was bringing a strange guest."

They settled in a spacious room with large windows overlooking the valley. The walls were covered with books—old, leather-bound volumes mixed with new editions. A fire burned in the stone fireplace.

"You want to understand," said Nikonor, pouring tea from a samovar of unusual design—heated by some invisible mechanism. "You want to understand how we came to this, from where you left us. From the horror, the hunger, the civil war, the dictatorship."

"Yes," said Kremnev quietly. "I want to understand."

Nikonor leaned back in his chair and began to speak, his voice low and resonant:

"The great collapse came in the late twenties. The industrialization, the collectivization, the terror—it all led to catastrophe. The cities were starving, the villages in revolt. The regime fell, not from outside attack, but from internal rottenness. And then—then the peasants took power."

"The peasants?"

"Yes, the peasants. Not the proletariat, not the party, not the intellectuals. The Russian peasantry, the real Russia, which had been pushed aside, humiliated, destroyed. They rose up, not in another bloody revolution, but simply by refusing to feed the cities, refusing to work for the factories. They returned to their land, their communes, their ancient ways."

"But how did they organize? How did they maintain culture, technology?"

"They organized themselves, as they always had. The mir, the village commune, became the unit of society. The artels, the cooperatives, took over production. The intelligentsia, those who survived, were forced to adapt—to become village teachers, doctors, agronomists. Those who refused perished or emigrated."

Nikonor paused and looked out the window at the golden autumn landscape.

"It was a terrible time, the years of the Great Return. Millions died. But those who survived found something new, something old and new at once. They found freedom in labor, dignity in cultivation, community in the village. And gradually, gradually, they built this."

He gestured toward the window.

"Not a return to primitive barbarism, as the old Marxists would say. A leap forward to a new synthesis. The best of technology, but human-scaled. The best of culture, but rooted in the soil. The machine, but the machine serving man, not man serving the machine."

Kremnev listened, fascinated and horrified. This was not the future he had worked for, not the socialism he had believed in. But it was undeniably a future, undeniably alive, undeniably human.

CHAPTER SEVEN
in which Kremnev becomes acquainted with the basics of the energy theory of culture

After lunch—a simple but abundant meal of vegetables, fruits, and bread—Nikonor led Kremnev to his study. The room was circular, with a domed ceiling painted with stars and constellations. In the center stood a strange apparatus—something between an orrery and an electrical generator, with spheres, rings, and glowing tubes.

"Do you know," asked Nikonor, "why the old civilization fell? Not because of war, not because of revolution. It fell because it violated the laws of energy. It consumed more than it produced. It burned the coal, the oil, the human souls—burned them in the furnaces of industry, without returning anything to the earth."

He approached the apparatus and touched a switch. The tubes began to glow with soft light, and the spheres slowly rotated.

"We have learned, Mr. Kremnev—we have learned to live within the solar budget. All our energy comes from the sun—directly, through solar collectors, or indirectly, through wind, water, and the growth of plants. We do not mine, we do not burn, we do not destroy. We cultivate, we harvest, we transform."

"But is that enough?" asked Kremnev. "Can solar energy really power a civilization?"

"Not the civilization you knew," smiled Nikonor. "Not the civilization of blast furnaces and assembly lines. But our civilization—light, dispersed, garden-like—yes, the sun is enough. We have learned to use it efficiently, to store it, to transform it. And most importantly—we have learned to need less."

He led Kremnev to a large chart on the wall—a complex diagram of circles, arrows, and numbers.

"This is the energy balance of our society. See: input from the sun, through agriculture and solar collectors. Output: heat, light, mechanical work, chemical synthesis. And see here—the cycle is closed. Everything returns to the soil, to the plants, to the sun-catchers. No waste, no depletion, no entropy increase."

"But culture?" asked Kremnev. "Art, science, philosophy? Surely these require more than just energy balance?"

"On the contrary," said Nikonor seriously. "They require exactly this. The old culture was sick because it was based on theft—from the earth, from the future, from other peoples. Our culture is healthy because it is based on reciprocity. We take from the sun, we give back to the earth. We take from the community, we give back through labor. We take knowledge from the past, we give back through teaching."

He walked to the window and pointed to the gardens below.

"Each of those trees, those plants, is a transformer of solar energy. Each of those people working among them is a transformer of biological energy into cultural energy. This is our philosophy, Mr. Kremnev. Not the dialectic of class struggle, but the harmony of energy flows. Not the dictatorship of the proletariat, but the sovereignty of the cultivator."

Kremnev looked at the chart, the apparatus, the old man's passionate face. It was a complete, coherent worldview—utterly different from Marxism, yet equally systematic, equally convinced of its own truth.

"And what about the state?" he asked. "The government? Surely you have not abolished all central authority?"

"We have the Council of Elders," replied Nikonor. "Representatives from each region, meeting to coordinate large projects, to settle disputes, to maintain the common infrastructure. But no standing army, no police, no bureaucracy. The commune is self-governing, self-policing, self-sustaining. We have returned, in essence, to the ancient Russian veche, the assembly of free citizens."

CHAPTER EIGHT
in which Kremnev visits an agricultural exhibition

The next day, Nikifor took Kremnev to the All-Russian Agricultural Exhibition, held that year on the former site of the revolutionary parades and military reviews. Kremnev expected something like the old industrial exhibitions—pavilions, machinery, crowds. What he found was entirely different.

The exhibition was spread over a vast area of parkland, with no fences, no gates, no tickets. People strolled leisurely along paths winding through groves and gardens. Here and there stood open pavilions—light, airy structures of wood and glass—each displaying some aspect of agricultural life.

"Look," said Nikifor, leading Kremnev to the first pavilion. "Our wheat."

The pavilion was filled with sheaves of grain—enormous, heavy heads of wheat, rye, barley, oats. Each variety was labeled with its characteristics: yield per acre, resistance to disease, nutritional value, taste. But what struck Kremnev was not the size or quantity, but the care with which everything was arranged—the aesthetic presentation of the sheaves, the beauty of the grains.

"We do not merely grow food," explained Nikifor. "We cultivate beauty. Each field is a composition, each harvest a work of art. The peasant is an artist, his field his canvas, his crops his colors."

They moved to the next pavilion—fruit. Here were apples of enormous size, pears of perfect form, grapes in clusters weighing several pounds. But again, it was not the size that impressed, but the arrangement—the sheaves of fruit displayed like bouquets, the careful labeling, the sense of pride and joy in cultivation.

"And this," said Nikifor, leading Kremnev to a large open area, "is our machinery."

Kremnev expected tractors, combines, the massive equipment of modern agriculture. Instead, he saw small, elegant machines—hand tools for the most part, with some larger devices powered by electricity or compressed air. Everything was designed for human scale, for individual or family use.

"Where are the tractors?" asked Kremnev. "The combines? The industrial farming equipment?"

"Gone," said Nikifor. "We found that they were inefficient, destructive to the soil, dehumanizing to the worker. These tools—each is made by a master craftsman, designed for a specific task, beautiful in itself. The cultivator knows his land, his plants, his tools. He does not need a machine to think for him."

They walked further, through pavilions of vegetables, flowers, herbs, through areas devoted to beekeeping, poultry, small livestock. Everywhere the same principles: small scale, human control, aesthetic care, local adaptation.

Finally, they came to the central pavilion—a large, domed structure where the prizes were displayed. Here were the best products of the year: the largest pumpkin, the finest wheat, the most perfect apple, the most beautiful flower arrangement. And beside each, the name of the cultivator, the village, the region.

"These are our heroes," said Nikifor quietly. "Not generals, not industrialists, not party leaders. Cultivators. Men and women who have coaxed the best from the earth, who have created beauty and abundance through their labor. This is our aristocracy, Mr. Men. The aristocracy of the soil."

Kremnev looked at the display—the proud names, the magnificent products, the evidence of a civilization built on different foundations than any he had known. He thought of the parades he had seen on this same ground—soldiers marching, tanks rolling, banners waving. And now—wheat, apples, pumpkins, flowers.

"This is your revolution?" he asked quietly.

"This is our evolution," replied Nikifor. "The revolution destroyed the old world. This—the garden, the cultivation, the return to the soil—this builds the new. Not through violence, but through growth. Not through conquest, but through cultivation. Not through the factory, but through the field."

The sun was setting, and the exhibition grounds were bathed in golden light. People were leaving, carrying small bundles of plants, seeds, tools—gifts from the exhibition to take back to their own gardens. Children ran laughing among the pavilions. Old men sat on benches, discussing the merits of different varieties.

And Kremnev felt, for the first time since his arrival, something like peace. The anxiety of strangeness, the tension of not understanding—both began to dissolve in the warmth of this autumn evening, in the sight of a world that, however different from his dreams, was undeniably human, undeniably alive, undeniably good.

CHAPTER NINE
in which Kremnev attends a village festival and learns the meaning of true leisure

Three days after the exhibition, Nikifor announced that they would be traveling to his native village for the autumn festival—the celebration of the harvest's end. They drove through the morning mist in a light electric carriage, passing from the garden-city of Moscow into the open countryside.

The village lay some eighty versts from the city—a journey that took them through endless orchards, past scattered settlements, across rivers spanned by elegant wooden bridges. Everywhere Kremnev saw the same pattern: small communities of fifty to a hundred households, each with its communal buildings, its workshops, its school, its meeting hall.

"How many people live in Russia now?" asked Kremnev.

"About forty million," replied Nikifor. "Fewer than in your time, but healthier, stronger, longer-lived. We found that a smaller population, well-nourished and well-educated, serves the land better than masses of half-starved laborers."

They arrived at the village of Gremyachka as the sun was beginning to set. The village consisted of some sixty houses, each surrounded by gardens, arranged in a rough circle around a large common meadow. In the center stood a tall wooden structure—the meeting hall and bell tower—its roof covered with carved wooden shingles.

The festival had already begun. In the meadow, long tables were set up, covered with white cloths and laden with food. Children ran between the tables, laughing and playing. Groups of young people danced to the music of fiddles and accordions. Older people sat on benches, talking and watching the festivities.

"Here," said Nikifor, leading Kremnev to a table, "you will see how we celebrate. Not in theaters, not in restaurants, not in private dining rooms. In the open air, together, as a community."

They sat down among Nikifor's relatives and neighbors. Kremnev was struck by the ease of their manners, the natural grace of their movements. These were peasants, descendants of peasants, yet they spoke of poetry, of philosophy, of scientific discoveries. They discussed the weather not as a threat or blessing, but as a partner in their agricultural work. They argued about the merits of different apple varieties with the passion of connoisseurs.

As darkness fell, the festival reached its height. Bonfires were lit around the meadow. The dancing became more energetic, the music more lively. Then, suddenly, a bell rang from the tower, and everyone fell silent.

An old man climbed onto a platform in the center of the meadow—the village elder, elected by the community to serve for a year. He raised his hand and spoke:

"Brothers and sisters! The harvest is gathered. The earth has given us her bounty. We have taken, and we have given back. The account is balanced. Let us give thanks!"

A chorus of voices rose in song—a simple, ancient melody that Kremnev recognized as a harvest hymn from old Russia, but with new words celebrating not just the gift of grain, but the harmony between human labor and natural growth.

Then came the feast. Course after course of simple but perfect food: soups of fresh vegetables, breads still warm from the oven, roasted meats from animals raised in the village, fruits and preserves, honey and nuts. And with the food, endless toasts—to the earth, to the sun, to the rain, to the ancestors, to the children, to the future.

Kremnev ate and drank, and felt a happiness he had not known in years—a happiness without anxiety, without the sense of impending doom that had haunted his life in 1921. These people were poor by the standards of the old world—no electricity in their houses, no running water, no automobiles. Yet they possessed something he had lost: a sense of belonging, of continuity, of being part of a cycle larger than themselves.

Late in the night, as the fires burned low and the stars wheeled overhead, Nikifor found him sitting alone on the edge of the meadow, looking at the dark mass of the forest beyond.

"What are you thinking?" asked Nikifor.

"I am thinking," said Kremnev slowly, "that I have spent my life chasing a future that was a mirage. I believed in progress, in industrialization, in the conquest of nature. And all the time, the real future—the human future—was here, in the past, in the simple things: the harvest, the community, the cycle of the seasons."

Nikifor sat beside him and was silent for a long time. Then he said:

"Do not judge yourself too harshly. Your generation faced impossible choices. You tried to build a just world with the tools of injustice, a humane world with the methods of inhumanity. It could not be done. We know this, because we inherited the ruins of your attempt."

He stood up and stretched.

"Come. The night is cold, and there is a bed waiting for you in my father's house. Tomorrow you will see how we work, and perhaps understand even more."

CHAPTER TEN
describing the labor of the Gremyachka commune and the education of the young

The next morning, Kremnev woke to the sound of voices and the smell of wood smoke. He rose and went to the window. Below, in the gardens surrounding the house, people were already at work.

He dressed quickly and went outside. Nikifor was waiting for him, holding two baskets.

"Today," he said, "you will work. Not as a visitor, not as an observer, but as a member of the commune. Here, everyone works, and everyone eats. There are no guests, only temporary members."

They walked to the communal orchard, where a group of men and women were harvesting the late apples. Nikifor handed Kremnev a basket and showed him how to climb the ladder, how to twist the fruit gently so that the stem came away without tearing the branch, how to place the apples carefully so they would not bruise.

At first, Kremnev was clumsy. His hands, accustomed to pen and paper, fumbled with the simple task. But gradually, he found a rhythm. The sun rose higher, warming his back. The smell of ripe apples filled his nostrils. He felt his muscles working, not painfully, but with a pleasant sense of effort and accomplishment.

They worked until noon, then broke for the midday meal. The workers gathered under a large oak tree, where a woman had set out bread, cheese, and a jug of cider. They sat on the grass, eating and talking, while children brought them water to wash their hands.

Kremnev found himself next to an old man who introduced himself as Fyodor, the village carpenter. He was gnarled and bent, with hands like twisted roots, but his eyes were bright and his voice strong.

"You are the visitor from the old times," said Fyodor. "I have heard of you. You were a Bolshevik, yes? A revolutionary?"

"I was," admitted Kremnev.

"Do not be ashamed. You fought for what you believed was right. And you were not wrong in your goals—only in your methods. The goal was justice, equality, the good life for all. But you thought you could achieve it through force, through taking from some to give to others. We have learned that the good life cannot be given. It must be grown, like these apples."

After the meal, they returned to work. In the afternoon, Kremnev was assigned to help in the school—a low, bright building on the edge of the village. He was to assist the history teacher, a young woman named Agafia, in a lesson about the Great Transformation.

The students were children of ten to twelve years old—bright-eyed, healthy, dressed in simple tunics and trousers. They sat on benches around a central table, on which lay maps and models.

"Today," said Agafia, "we will hear from our guest, who lived in the time before the Transformation. He will tell us what life was like, and you may ask him questions."

Kremnev stood before the children, suddenly nervous. How could he explain the world he had known—the hunger, the fear, the violence, the desperate hope? He began to speak, haltingly at first, then with growing confidence. He told them of the cities, the factories, the machines. He told them of the revolution, the civil war, the terror. He told them of the belief that had sustained him and his comrades: that through suffering, through sacrifice, through the destruction of the old world, a new world would be born.

The children listened in silence. When he finished, a boy raised his hand.

"Did you have gardens?" he asked.

"Some did," said Kremnev. "But most people lived in cities, in apartments. They bought their food in stores."

"And they did not know how it was grown?"

"No. They did not know."

Another child, a girl, raised her hand.

"Were they happy?"

Kremnev paused. "Some were. Some were not. Many were afraid. Many were hungry."

"And you," asked the girl, "are you happier here, with us?"

Kremnev looked at her—at her clear eyes, her healthy skin, her confident posture. He thought of the children he had known in 1921—the ragged, hungry, frightened children of Moscow.

"Yes," he said quietly. "I am happier here."

CHAPTER ELEVEN
in which Kremnev learns of the fate of the old revolutionary generation

That evening, after the evening meal, Kremnev sat with Nikifor and his father, an old man named Savva, on the porch of the family house. The night was warm, and the stars were brilliant in the clear sky.

"Tell me," said Kremnev, "what happened to the others? The Bolsheviks, the revolutionaries, the people I knew?"

Savva was silent for a long time, puffing on a long-stemmed pipe. Then he spoke:

"Most died. In the wars, in the famines, in the purges. Some escaped abroad. A few survived, adapted, became part of the new world. But the ideology died. It had to die, because it was based on a false premise."

"What premise?"

"That man is primarily a producer, an economic agent. That the purpose of society is to maximize production, to accumulate wealth, to conquer nature. We have learned that man is primarily a cultivator, a caretaker, a participant in natural cycles. The purpose of society is

not to produce more, but to live well; not to accumulate, but to maintain balance; not to conquer nature, but to cooperate with it."

"But the revolution," said Kremnev. "The overthrow of the old order. Surely that was necessary?"

"Perhaps," said Savva. "The old order was unjust, cruel, destructive. It had to end. But what replaced it was, in many ways, worse. The Bolsheviks tried to create a new society through force, through centralization, through the destruction of all traditional bonds. They created a machine of state power more terrible than anything the tsars had imagined. And in the end, that machine destroyed itself—and nearly destroyed Russia with it."

He paused, drawing on his pipe.

"The Great Famine of 1929-1931 killed millions. The collectivization destroyed the village communes that had sustained Russia for centuries. The purges of the 1930s decimated the intelligentsia. The Second World War, when it came, found a weakened, demoralized country. And after the war, the system simply collapsed under its own weight."

"And then?"

"And then the Return. The peasants, who had never fully accepted collectivization, simply walked away from the collective farms. They returned to their ancestral lands, rebuilt their villages, restored the old ways. The cities emptied. The factories closed. The party dissolved. And slowly, over decades, the new order emerged—not planned, not imposed, but grown, like a garden."

Kremnev thought of his comrades—the idealistic young men and women with whom he had worked, dreamed, fought. Trotsky, exiled and murdered. Bukharin, executed. The thousands, millions who had believed as he had believed.

"Was it all for nothing?" he asked.

"Not for nothing," said Nikifor gently. "You were the necessary catastrophe. You cleared the ground. You destroyed the old regime so completely that it could never return. You demonstrated the failure of industrial civilization so dramatically that no one could doubt it. You were the fire that burned the forest, making way for new growth."

"But we wanted to build, not destroy."

"You cannot build a new world with old materials. The materials of the old world—coal, iron, the factory system, the proletariat—were inherently destructive. You tried to build a humane society with inhumane tools. It was impossible. The new world is built of different materials—sunlight, soil, human skill, community bonds. These were the materials you rejected, the 'backwardness' you sought to overcome. And in the end, they were the only materials that could sustain a human civilization."

Kremnev sat in silence, watching the stars. He thought of the decades he had missed—the suffering, the transformation, the slow emergence of this new world. He felt both grief and relief: grief for the failure of his dreams, relief that something human had survived.

"I would like to see more," he said finally. "I would like to understand more."

"You will," said Savva. "There is time. You are one of us now, for as long as you wish to stay. And there is much to learn."

CHAPTER TWELVE
describing Kremnev's journey to the Academy and his conversation with the historians

A week later, Nikifor announced that they would be traveling to the Academy of Sciences in the former city of Leningrad—or Petrograd, as it was now called again. There, Kremnev would have the opportunity to meet with historians who specialized in the period of the Great Transformation.

They traveled by boat down the river, then by train—a curious vehicle that ran on electricity, silent and smooth, through the autumn landscape. The journey took two days, and they stopped at several villages along the way, staying with local families, sharing their food, learning their ways.

Petrograd was much changed from the city Kremnev remembered. The enormous apartment buildings, the factories, the barracks—all were gone. In their place stretched gardens, parks, and low wooden buildings in the traditional Russian style. Only the historic center—the Winter Palace, the Admiralty, the cathedrals—remained, preserved as monuments to a bygone age.

The Academy occupied a large complex of buildings on the outskirts of the former city—low, comfortable structures surrounded by gardens and laboratories. Here, scholars worked on agriculture, biology, astronomy, and the study of history.

Kremnev was received by a group of historians led by a venerable old woman named Sophia, who was said to be over ninety years old and had lived through the entire period of the Transformation.

"We have been expecting you," she said, leading him to a comfortable study lined with books. "Your case is unique. There have been others who survived from the revolutionary period—frozen, hidden, preserved in various ways. But you are the first to come to us with memory intact, with the ability to explain the old world from within."

She asked him to tell his story, and he did—more fully than he had to Nikifor or Paraskeva. He spoke of his childhood, his education, his conversion to socialism, his work in the Soviet apparatus, his growing doubts, his reading of Herzen on that fatal night, his awakening in 1984.

Sophia listened intently, occasionally making notes. When he finished, she was silent for a long time.

"You are a valuable witness," she said finally. "We have documents from your time, of course—archives, newspapers, official records. But we have few personal accounts from the middle-level functionaries, the people who actually made the system work. You can help us understand how it was possible—how intelligent, idealistic people could participate in such a destructive system."

"I believed," said Kremnev simply. "I believed we were building a better world. I believed the ends justified the means. I believed that suffering now would mean happiness later."

"And now?"

"Now I see that the means determine the ends. You cannot build a free society through tyranny, a just society through injustice, a humane society through cruelty. The methods you use become the foundation of what you build. We built on sand—on violence, lies, and fear. No wonder our building collapsed."

Sophia nodded. "That is the lesson we have learned. The society we have built is not perfect. It is poor in material goods, limited in its achievements, fragile in many ways. But it is built on truth—on the truth of human dependence on nature, on the truth of the value of labor, on the truth of community. It may not last forever. But it will not collapse from internal rottenness, as yours did."

She rose and walked to a window overlooking the gardens.

"Stay with us," she said. "Teach us what you know. Learn from us what we have learned. And perhaps, together, we can ensure that the mistakes of the past are not repeated."

Kremnev looked out at the peaceful scene—the scholars walking along the paths, the students working in the gardens, the autumn sun casting long shadows across the grass.

"I will stay," he said. "I have nowhere else to go, and nothing else to do. Perhaps, in helping you understand the past, I can atone for my part in creating it."

CHAPTER THIRTEEN
in which Kremnev studies the archives of the old world and confronts the weight of memory

Winter came to Petrograd. The gardens that had been lush and green when Kremnev arrived were now bare, their branches covered with snow. The wooden buildings of the Academy stood half-buried in drifts, smoke rising from their chimneys into the gray sky.

Kremnev had been given a small room in one of the scholars' dormitories—a simple space with a bed, a desk, a stove, and a window overlooking the frozen gardens. It was more than he had had in 1921, and he found it comfortable.

His work at the Academy consisted primarily of reading and commenting on documents from the revolutionary period. The archives were extensive—tons of paper rescued from the destruction of the old regime, preserved in climate-controlled cellars beneath the Academy buildings.

Each morning, Kremnev would descend into the archives, accompanied by a young assistant named Dmitry. Together they would open boxes, unfold documents, and Kremnev would explain what they meant—the bureaucratic language, the ideological phrases, the terrible realities hidden behind euphemisms.

He read his own reports, written in the heat of the civil war, justifying requisitions that had starved villages. He read the minutes of meetings where he had voted for measures he now knew to have been criminal. He read his correspondence with comrades, most of whom were now dead, discussing the building of socialism while the country burned around them.

At first, he read with detachment, as if these documents concerned someone else. But gradually, the reality of what he had done pressed upon him. He began to have nightmares—dreams of the faces of the peasants he had condemned, the villages he had helped to destroy, the comrades he had betrayed to save himself.

One night, he woke screaming. Dmitry came running and found him sitting up in bed, his face covered with sweat, his eyes wild.

"They are all dead," Kremnev whispered. "And I killed them."

"You did not kill them with your own hands," said Dmitry gently.

"I might as well have. I wrote the orders. I signed the decrees. I justified the crimes with my theories, my ideology, my belief in the future."

Dmitry sat with him until morning, listening as Kremnev talked—about the revolution, the civil war, the hope that had turned to ash. He spoke of things he had never told anyone, secrets he had carried for decades.

In the morning, Kremnev refused to go down to the archives.

"I cannot," he said. "I cannot look at those papers anymore. I cannot face what I was."

Sophia came to see him. She sat by his bed, her ancient face calm and compassionate.

"You are experiencing what we call the judgment of memory," she said. "It happens to all who survive from the old world. The weight of what they did, or what was done to them, becomes too heavy to bear."

"What can I do?" asked Kremnev.

"You can accept it. You can acknowledge what you did, without excuse, without justification. And then you can ask: what can I do now? How can I serve the living, rather than atone to the dead?"

"But the dead deserve justice."

"The dead are beyond justice. Only the living can be helped. You have knowledge, experience, understanding of a world that is otherwise lost. That knowledge can help us avoid repeating the mistakes of the past. But only if you are willing to use it."

Kremnev was silent for a long time. Then he rose from his bed and dressed.

"Take me back to the archives," he said. "I have work to finish."

CHAPTER FOURTEEN
telling of the spring festival and Kremnev's growing integration into the new world

Winter passed, and spring came to Petrograd. The snow melted, the gardens greened, and the Academy prepared for the spring festival—the celebration of planting, of new beginnings, of the return of life to the earth.

Kremnev had spent the winter months working intensively on the archives. He had compiled a history of the Soviet bureaucracy—how it had functioned, how it had grown, how it had eventually consumed the revolution it claimed to serve. His work was praised by the Academy scholars, and he had begun to feel a sense of purpose he had not known since his arrival.

But more than the work, it was the daily life of the Academy that had changed him. He had learned to garden, to cook, to care for animals. He had made friends—Dmitry, Sophia, and others who accepted him not as a relic from the past, but as a fellow worker in the present.

The spring festival was held in the Academy gardens. All work was suspended for three days, and the scholars, students, and workers gathered to celebrate the turning of the seasons.

On the first day, they prepared the soil. In the old world, Kremnev would have seen this as mere labor, to be minimized and mechanized. Now he understood it as ritual, as communion with the earth. He worked alongside the others, turning the soil, breaking the clods, feeling the spring sun on his back.

On the second day, they planted. Each person had their own plot, their own seeds, their own hopes for the harvest. Kremnev planted potatoes and carrots—humble crops, but essential. As he placed each seed in the ground, he felt a connection to something larger than himself, something that stretched back through generations of cultivators.

On the third day, they celebrated. There was music and dancing, feasting and drinking, speeches and songs. In the evening, as the sun set, Sophia rose to speak.

"We are gathered," she said, "to welcome the spring and to welcome a new member of our community. Alexei Kremnev came to us from the distant past, from a world of darkness and destruction. He has worked with us, learned with us, grown with us. He has shown us that even those who served the old system can change, can grow, can become part of something better."

She turned to Kremnev.

"Alexei Vasilyevich, will you accept the obligations of membership in our community? Will you work honestly, share freely, and care for the earth and your fellow human beings?"

Kremnev stood, his heart full. "I will," he said.

"Then you are one of us," said Sophia. "Not a guest, not a visitor, but a member of the commune, with all the rights and obligations that entails."

The crowd cheered. People came forward to embrace him, to welcome him, to offer gifts—seeds, tools, books, food. Kremnev felt tears running down his face—tears of gratitude, of relief, of a happiness he had never expected to know again.

That night, he walked alone in the gardens. The moon was full, casting silver light on the newly turned earth. He thought of his brother Alexei, for whom the book was named—his brother who had died in the civil war, fighting for a future that had never come.

"I am sorry," he whispered to the night. "I am sorry for what we did, what we tried to do. But perhaps, in the end, something good has grown from the ashes. Perhaps your death was not entirely in vain."

The moon was silent, but the earth seemed to breathe beneath his feet, and he felt, for the first time in decades, at peace.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

in which Kremnev receives a visitor from the past and must choose his future

Summer came, and with it a visitor. Kremnev was working in his garden when Dmitry came running with the news.

"There is someone to see you," he said. "A woman. She says she knew you—in the old time."

Kremnev wiped his hands and went to the Academy's guest house. There, waiting in the garden, stood a woman of about sixty—thin, weathered, with gray hair and sharp, intelligent eyes. She looked at him, and he looked at her, and for a moment neither spoke.

Then Kremnev recognized her. "Anna?" he whispered.

"Alexei," she said. "I did not believe it when I heard. But it is you. You have not aged a day."

Anna Sergeyevna—he had known her in 1919, in the early days of the revolution. They had worked together in the food requisitioning committees. They had been lovers, briefly, in the chaos of those years. Then she had been arrested, accused of sabotage, and he had denounced her to save himself. He had thought her dead.

"But how?" he asked. "I thought—"

"You thought they shot me," she said. "They did not. They sent me to the camps. I survived—barely. And when the system collapsed, I was released. I made my way east, to Siberia, and joined one of the new communes. I have lived there ever since."

They sat in the garden, and she told him her story—the years in the camps, the hunger, the cold, the deaths of so many. But also the survival, the adaptation, the eventual freedom.

"And you?" she asked. "How did you escape? How did you come here, unchanged?"

Kremnev told her—about the night in his study, about reading Herzen, about the strange transition that had brought him to 1984.

Anna listened, her face unreadable. When he finished, she was silent for a long time.

"Do you know," she said finally, "what I thought about, in the camps? I thought about you. I thought about how you betrayed me, how you saved yourself while I suffered. I hated you, Alexei. For years, my hatred was the only thing that kept me alive."

Kremnev bowed his head. "I am sorry," he said. "I have no excuse. I was afraid. I wanted to live. I told myself that the revolution needed me, that my survival was more important than your life. I was wrong."

"Yes," she said. "You were wrong. But you were not the only one. Everyone betrayed everyone, in those years. That was the nature of the system—it turned comrades against each other, friends against friends, lovers against lovers. You were a product of your time, as I was of mine."

She stood and walked to the edge of the garden, looking out at the fields.

"I did not come here for revenge," she said. "I came because I heard that a man from the past had appeared, and I wondered if it could be you. And now that I have seen you, I find

that my hatred is gone. You are not the monster I imagined. You are just a man, like any other, with your weaknesses and your strengths."

She turned to face him.

"I have a proposition for you. I am returning to Siberia tomorrow. My commune needs people—strong people, educated people, people who can help us build. Come with me, Alexei. Leave this place of scholars and books. Come to the real Russia, the working Russia, and help us cultivate the earth."

Kremnev was torn. He had found a place here at the Academy, a purpose, a community. But Anna was offering something else—a chance to truly begin again, to leave the past behind completely, to become someone new.

"I need time to think," he said.

"You have until tomorrow," she said. "Then I leave, with or without you."

CHAPTER SIXTEEN
describing Kremnev's decision and his departure for Siberia

That night, Kremnev did not sleep. He walked through the Academy gardens, thinking, weighing his options.

If he stayed, he would continue his work as a scholar, preserving the memory of the past, helping the new world understand the old. It was valuable work, necessary work. But it was also safe, comfortable, removed from the real struggles of life.

If he went with Anna, he would be starting over completely. He would be a novice again, learning to work the land in the harsh conditions of Siberia. It would be hard, dangerous, uncertain. But it would be real, immediate, connected to the earth.

He thought of his brother Alexei, who had died fighting for a future he never saw. He thought of the peasants he had wronged, the comrades he had betrayed, the ideals he had corrupted. Could he atone for all that through scholarship? Or did he need to suffer, to struggle, to truly change?

In the morning, he went to see Sophia. She was in her study, as always, surrounded by books.

"You have decided," she said. It was not a question.

"Yes," he said. "I am going with Anna. I am sorry to leave you, to leave the work—"

She held up her hand. "Do not apologize. You have given us enough—more than enough. Your work will remain, and others will continue it. But you are not meant to be a scholar, Alexei. You are a man of action, of struggle. You need to test yourself, to prove that you can be different."

She rose and embraced him.

"Go with my blessing. And remember—wherever you go, whatever you do, you are part of this world now. Not a visitor, not an exile, but a Russian, a cultivator, a child of the earth."

He packed his few belongings—clothes, tools, the books he had been given. Dmitry came to say goodbye, and they embraced like brothers.

"Will you come back?" asked Dmitry.

"Perhaps," said Kremnev. "Someday. When I have something worth showing."

Anna was waiting at the gate. She had a cart, drawn by two sturdy horses, loaded with supplies for the journey. They climbed aboard, and Kremnev took the reins.

As they drove away from the Academy, Kremnev looked back at the buildings, the gardens, the scholars walking in the morning sun. He had been happy here. But happiness, he had learned, was not enough. One needed purpose, struggle, growth.

They drove through the streets of Petrograd—past the gardens, past the churches, past the people going about their daily work. Then they were in the countryside, the open road stretching before them, leading east, toward the rising sun.

"Tell me about Siberia," said Kremnev.

"It is hard," said Anna. "The winters are long and cold. The work is endless. But the land is rich, and the people are good. We have built something there, Alexei. Something real. Not a utopia, not a paradise, but a human community, living in balance with nature. You will see."

They drove on, through the summer day, into the future. Behind them lay the past—the revolution, the terror, the mistakes, the deaths. Ahead lay the unknown—the struggle, the possibility, the hope.

Kremnev felt the sun on his face and the wind in his hair. He was alive, and he was free, and for the first time in his long life, he knew who he was and what he was meant to do.

The road stretched before them, endless and open, and Alexei Kremnev, former Bolshevik, former exile from time, drove forward into his new life.

The author died before completing the second half of the book.